Stone Age technology paths

A practical crafting scope: from our ~200,000-year starting point through the Neolithic. **No wheels or metalworking.**

How to read this report. "Starting toolkit" means historically appropriate knowledge, not equipment everyone spawns with. Regional traditions, materials and proficiency still matter. Later finds provide evidence of availability, not exact invention dates.

† Plausible reconstruction: suitable for gameplay consideration, but not securely demonstrated at the stated starting date. The Neolithic is the final part of the Stone Age; its dates vary by region.

01 Weapons

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

Clubs, handheld stone cutting tools, wooden spears; stone-tipped spear technology.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Bows and arrows, spear-throwers, improved spearheads and stone-headed maces. Slings and wooden/hide shields† are optional branches. [01], [03]

02 Hunting, trapping & fishing

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

Hunting spears, digging implements and butchery tools. Simple capture barriers†.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Bone harpoons, fishhooks and line, nets, basket traps and fish weirs. Snares and deadfalls† fit progression after reliable bindings. [08]

03 Medicine & injury care

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

No securely reconstructable standardized medical kit. Supporting an injured person, protecting wounds and immobilizing injuries are plausible practices†.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Better dressings, splints, locally learned plant preparations† and specialist treatment tools. Some Stone Age surgery and dentistry are evidenced; these remain exceptional practices. [13], [15]

04 Clothing & body protection

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

Hide scraping and preparation; simple draped skins or wraps†.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Pierced and sewn garments, bone needles, fitted cold-weather clothing, footwear, belts, hats and woven plant-fibre clothing. Protective hide garments or padding† offer modest protection. [01], [09]

Crafting, food & materials

These processes enable several kinds of equipment. They should not be hidden inside a single enormous “tools” menu.

05 Carrying, containers & storage

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

Simple hide bundles and useful natural containers†.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Sewn bags, baskets, bark containers, wooden bowls, ceramic pots and storage jars. Back-carriers†, storage pits and granaries provide larger upgrades.

06 Food preparation & preservation

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

Butchery, cracking and pounding foods, and cooking over fire.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Specialized grinding, boiling and stewing, ovens, flatbread, fermentation and dairy processing. Drying, smoking and salt-curing fit practical progression; their earliest origins are difficult to date. [10], [16]

07 Fire, lighting & heating

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

Hearths, maintaining fire and carrying embers†. Deliberate ignition where technique and suitable materials are known.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Friction-fire kits, torches, fat lamps, improved hearths, earth ovens and clay ovens. Fire supports material crafts as well as cooking. [02]

08 Tools & material processing

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

Hammerstones, flakes, handaxes, scrapers, worked wood and basic bone implements.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Specialized blades, awls, drills, saw-like tools, hafted axes and adzes, polished cutting edges, wedges and advanced carpentry tools. [01], [04], [11]

09 Fibre, adhesives & ceramics

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

Basic woodworking and material selection; some composite-tool technology exists. Do not assume every group has a sophisticated adhesive recipe.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Twisted cord, rope, braiding, matting, basketry, spinning, weaving, improved adhesives and sealants, pottery and controlled firing. A major enabling branch. [07], [09]

Camp, movement & settlement

Building capability grows with materials, preparation, labour and knowledge. Agriculture is not a prerequisite for every advanced hunter-gatherer craft.

10 Shelter & construction

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

Windbreaks, simple branch shelters and rough shelter frames†; using and improving natural shelters.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Hide tents, thatched huts, earth-covered shelters, wattle-and-daub, mudbrick and stone houses, substantial timber buildings, fences, platforms and modest footbridges†. [05], [11], [12]

11 Furniture & camp fittings

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

Grass bedding; conveniently placed logs or stones for sitting†.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Mats, hide bedding, raised sleeping platforms†, racks, pegs, shelves, storage bins and built-in stone beds. Wooden stools, tables and framed beds† become plausible with joinery. [06], [12]

12 Travel, hauling & watercraft

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

Walking with carried loads; improvised hauling arrangements†.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Drag sledges, carrying frames†, dugout canoes, paddles and regional watercraft. Animal-assisted hauling can follow suitable domestication. No wheeled vehicles. [08]

13 Water & camp sanitation

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

Collecting water from available sources. Separating waste from sleeping areas†.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Water-carrying vessels, settling/straining†, boiling with suitable containers, rain collection†, dug and lined wells, drainage and organized waste disposal. [11]

14 Cultivation & animal keeping

STARTING TOOLKIT · ~200,000 YEARS AGO

Wild-food gathering and digging tools—not established farming or livestock.

LATER STONE AGE UNLOCKS

Plant tending, sowing, harvesting, seed selection, crop storage, livestock, pens and dairying. Dogs belong to later Stone Age progression, but their domestication predates farming. [11], [16]

What can we actually build?

Stone tools do not limit us to crude huts. Substantial houses belong near the top of this scope; preparing and transporting their materials should be the challenge.

BUILDING	RECOMMENDATION
Branch-and-leaf lean-to	Starting option†. Modest protection and limited durability.
Conical pole-and-hide tent	Include after adequate hide preparation and bindings. Use a generic description rather than claiming the specific historical tipi design for every prehistoric group.
Thatch or reed hut	Strong later option: poles, bindings and locally suitable roofing plants.
Wattle-and-daub house	Within the Neolithic ceiling: woven framework covered with an earth mixture.
Earth-covered or turf shelter	Regional construction family†, dependent on drainage, climate and materials.
Stone house	Definitely within scope by the Neolithic. Skara Brae preserves stone houses and built-in furniture. [12]
Substantial timber house	Within scope. Neolithic wells demonstrate substantial worked timbers and sophisticated joints; metal nails are not required. [11]
Log-built structure	Credible later option. Preserved log well constructions establish capability, without proving every modern cabin design existed. [11]
Classic block-built igloo	Optional cold-climate invention†, not a 200,000-year baseline. The documented Arctic tradition is much later. Simple snow windbreaks or excavated snow shelters† are easier early allowances. [14]

Beds are a clear inclusion. Grass bedding is evidenced around 200,000 years ago. Neolithic Skara Brae had stone box-beds, storage furniture and hearths. Elaborate backed chairs are a less secure default than simple seats, stools or built-in benches. [6, 12]

Medicine needs restraint. Exact preparations and effectiveness are rarely recoverable. Even the beeswax dental filling is interpreted cautiously by its researchers. Avoid interchangeable herb-based healing potions. [13]

Design the unlocks as processes

Keep three constraints separate: **technology** is knowing the process; **ability** is performing it well; **materials** determine what is possible locally. Culture affects transmission and established practice.

Cordage: Stronger bindings, carrying straps, net-making and some construction.

Hide preparation & sewing: Fitted clothing, bags, coverings and bedding.

Controlled clay firing: Pots, cooking vessels and larger storage containers.

Wood joinery: Better buildings, furniture, wells and wooden structures.

Grinding & food processing: New foods, independently of whether ingredients are cultivated.

Knowing how to make a bow is technology; making a dependable bow and shooting accurately are different skills. Recipes should use properties such as suitable fibres, workable timber and knappable stone—not require particular real-world species names.

Evidence & further reading

[01] Smithsonian — Stone tools

[02] Nature — Fire-making evidence around 400,000 years ago

[03] PLOS ONE — Early stone-tipped projectiles

[04] Nature — Systematic bone tools at 1.5 million years

[05] Nature — Structural wood use at Kalambo Falls

[06] Science / SUNY — Grass bedding around 200,000 years ago

[07] Scientific Reports — Neanderthal fibre technology

[08] National Museum of Denmark — Mesolithic coastal equipment

[09] Natural History Museum Vienna — Textile equipment

[10] PNAS — Bread-like foods before agriculture

[11] PLOS ONE — Neolithic wooden wells and carpentry

[12] Historic Environment Scotland — Skara Brae houses and furniture

[13] PLOS ONE — Possible Neolithic beeswax dental filling

[14] Library and Archives Canada — Inuit snow-house tradition

[15] Scientific Reports — Neolithic cranial surgery

[16] Nature — Neolithic cheese-making evidence

Evidence establishes particular populations and practices, not universal knowledge. † entries are explicit design inferences; missing organic remains do not demonstrate that a technology was absent.